

# Case 9: The Rival's Surprise Launch

Competitive Response

Framework: 4A (Awareness, Acceptability, Affordability, Accessibility)

## RECOMMENDED DECISION

### Respond differently — don't copy, don't ignore.

NovaTel should not clone the rival's throttled "free weekend data" offer, and should not stay silent either. The right move is a transparency-led counter-offer that turns the rival's weakest 4A dimensions — Accessibility (new customers only) and Affordability (hidden throttling) — into NovaTel's strength, while moving fast enough to capture the weekend news cycle.

## Framework Analysis: 4A Diagnosis of the Rival Offer

### AWARENESS — Strong

2,100+ mentions on X, 640 on Instagram; went semi-viral organically over the weekend via WhatsApp forwards.

*Implication: the buzz is real — ignoring it risks looking out of touch.*

### ACCESSIBILITY — Weak

Offer is restricted to NEW customers only — existing, loyal customers are excluded.

*Implication: exploitable gap — NovaTel can win on inclusiveness by rewarding existing customers.*

### AFFORDABILITY — Deceptive

"Free" data is capped at 2GB, then throttled to unusable speeds — fine print undercuts the headline claim.

*Implication: real value is much smaller than the buzz suggests.*

### ACCEPTABILITY — Mixed

55–74% positive across platforms, but skeptical/negative share (26–45%) is rising as fine print comes to light.

*Implication: sentiment will likely sour on its own within days.*

Green = advantage to defend against | Red = exploitable weakness | Amber = watch closely

## Discussion Question Responses

### 1. Should NovaTel copy this offer, ignore it, or respond with something different?

Respond differently. Copying invites NovaTel into the same trap the rival set for itself — a headline that collapses under scrutiny, which would cost NovaTel credibility once its own throttling kicked in. Ignoring it is equally risky: the 4A analysis shows Awareness is genuinely high, and NovaTel's own customers are already asking for a comparable offer, so silence reads as slow or indifferent. The better path is a distinct counter-offer built on the rival's two weakest dimensions: launch a weekend data benefit open to *all* customers, including existing ones (fixing the rival's Accessibility gap), with clear, honest terms and no hidden throttle (fixing the rival's Affordability gap). This lets NovaTel ride the same news cycle while positioning itself as the trustworthy alternative rather than a copycat.

### 2. Is this rival move actually a threat, or mostly noise that will fade once customers hit the fine print?

It is mostly noise with a real underlying signal. The offer's substance is thin — new-customers-only, capped at 2GB, throttled afterward — so it is unlikely to drive durable share shift once early adopters hit the cap and word spreads (Reddit skepticism at 45% is already an early warning sign). However, the signal underneath the noise is real: there is genuine, unmet demand for affordable weekend data, evidenced by NovaTel's own customers asking for something similar. Treat the offer itself as a low threat, but treat the demand it exposed as a real strategic opening.

### 3. If you were on NovaTel's leadership team, what would you tell customers by Monday afternoon?

A short, confident public statement acknowledging the conversation directly: "We've heard you — weekend data matters. Unlike other offers out there, ours will be available to every NovaTel customer, new or existing, with no hidden speed cuts." This should be paired with a fast-follow internal workstream to finalize real commercial terms within the week, so the public statement is backed by a credible, deliverable offer rather than a reactive promise.

#### KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The 4A framework turns a competitor's "win" into a diagnostic — awareness and buzz are not the same as a sustainable offer.
- Fine print gaps (Accessibility, Affordability) are the fastest way to differentiate without a price war.
- Speed matters more than perfection — a same-week credible response beats a slower, more polished one once a story is already viral.